Minutes of the
General Government Committee
Operating Budget Meeting
Held in the Council Chambers, Ajax Town Hall
At 7:00 p.m. on February 3, 2020

Alternative formats available upon request by contacting:
accessibility@ajax.ca or 905-619-2529 ext. 3347

Present:	Chair - Councillor	R. Tyler Morin
	Regional Councillors	M. Crawford
		S. Lee
		J. Dies
	Councillors	A. Khan
		L. Bower
	Mayor	S. Collier

1. Call to Order

Chair Tyler Morin called the meeting to order at 7:00 p.m.

2. Disclosure of Pecuniary Interest

Councillor Bower declared a pecuniary interest with respect to the 'Recreation & Culture: Recreation Programming & Active Living' section of the budget, as she has a family member who works for that area of the Town.

Mayor Collier declared a pecuniary interest with respect to the 'Recreation & Culture: Recreation Programming & Active Living' section of the budget, as he has a family member who works for that area of the Town.

Neither member participated in or influenced any discussions regarding salaries or wages for staff in the RPAL section of Recreation.

3. Opening Comments/Presentation

Sandra Serrao, Acting Director of Finance/Treasurer, delivered a presentation on the proposed 2020 Operating Budget. S. Serrao discussed the operating budget overview, process and timelines, operating budget framework, 2020 net operating budget, expenditures by category, funding and revenue sources, exceptions to the tax rate, operating budget pressures, proposed tax rate increase, distribution of property taxes, comparison to previous years, comparison to other municipalities, and budget savings initiatives.

Councillor Tyler Morin, Budget Chair, thanked staff for their hard work on the budget and reviewed highlights of the proposed budget.

4. Opening Public Comments/Questions

Chair Tyler Morin invited comments and questions from the public on the proposed 2020 Operating Budget.

Chris Baker, 69 Darley Street, sought clarification on the dollar amount of a 1% increase in taxation, share of taxation between residential and non-residential properties, calculation of the average assessed property value, and whether taxation from new properties covers the costs for assuming services for those properties. S. Serrao noted the dollar amount of a 1% tax increase and the relative share of taxation between residential and non-residential properties in Ajax. Catherine Bridgeman, Director of Operations & Environmental Services, and Shane Baker, Chief Administrative Officer, reviewed operating costs and taxation revenues associated with new properties and subdivisions.

Ceciley White, 10 Heatherwood Road, inquired about the Town's use of reserve funds to support the operating budget and how reserves are replenished. S. Serrao explained the use of reserve funds in the operating budget, and funding sources for the replenishment of the Town's reserves.

Ann Hooper, 93 Pittmann Crescent, inquired about the tax rate increase associated with the opening of ARC Phase 2 and allocations to the Town's seniors' centre. S. Serrao explained the costs associated with opening ARC Phase 2. Robert Gruber, Manager of Community & Cultural Development, reviewed the Recreation & Culture Master Plan under development and its impact on future plans for the seniors' centre.

5. Review of Budget

Chair Tyler Morin led the Committee through a section-by-section review of the proposed 2020 Operating Budget. Committee Members asked questions on the following sections and topics.

Section 1 – Budget Report

There were no questions or comments on the budget report.

Section 2: Operating Budget

Members provided questions and comments on the following sections within the proposed 2020 Operating Budget:

- **All Departments – Summary (p. 4-7):** Committee Members asked questions and made comments regarding 2020 proposed budgets compared to 2019 forecasted expenditures, hardware and software licensing costs, reference checking service, administrative and miscellaneous program costs, and the election contribution rebates program. Nicole Cooper, Director of Legislative & Information Services / Town Clerk, discussed the Town's hardware and software licensing process and

the election contribution rebate program. S. Baker reviewed the use and purpose of the reference checking service.

- **Legislative & Information Services (p. 17-19):** Committee Members asked questions regarding bank charges associated with the parking management system and potential to collect fees from the Town's on-street parking permit program. N. Cooper reviewed costs associated with the parking management system and the potential for revenues from the on-street parking permit system.

- **Fire & Emergency Services (p. 20-22):** Committee Members asked questions regarding the regional radio communication system contractual costs. Dave Lang, Fire Chief, reviewed the regional radio communication system and terms of the Town's contract with the region.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Environmental Services (p. 29-32):** Committee Members asked questions regarding the Greenwood rental property lease. C. Bridgeman discussed the rental property lease at Greenwood and the condition of the property.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Fleet / Equipment Maintenance (p. 33-34):** Committee Members asked questions regarding proposed new vehicle rentals to cover shortfall of fleet vehicles, and sharing of vehicles between departments. C. Bridgeman and S. Baker reviewed the proposed vehicle rentals and fleet utilization study.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Building Maintenance (p. 35-36):** Committee Members asked questions regarding Town Hall utility costs. C. Bridgeman spoke about the upcoming energy conservation demand management plan.

- **Recreation, Culture & Community Development – Facilities (p. 42-44):** Committee Members asked questions regarding increased contract security costs, differential between 2020 projected revenues and 2019 forecasted actual revenues, and insurance costs. R. Gruber discussed the requirement for additional contracted security at Town facilities and discussed budgeting practices for estimating revenues. S. Serrao reviewed revenue estimations and calculation of insurance costs.

- **Planning & Development Services (p. 50-52):** Committee Members asked questions regarding costs associated with implementation of the UpNext Program. Geoff Romanowski, Acting Director of Planning & Development Services, reviewed the UpNext program and associated costs.

- **Budget Section Summary (p. 53-70):** Committee Members asked questions regarding parking enforcement net operating budget amounts, and trails maintenance. N. Cooper and C. Bridgeman responded to questions from Committee Members.

Section 3: Staff Requests

Members asked questions and made comments regarding Staff Requests within Section 3 of the Operating Budget:

- **'Senior Financial Analyst' (p. 73):** Committee Members asked questions regarding the position's role in performing internal audit functions. S. Serrao described the new positions' responsibilities for performing internal auditing.

- **'Asset Management – Facilities' & 'Capital Project and Asset Management Supervisor – Facilities' (p. 74-75):** Committee Members sought clarification on the roles and responsibilities of the two proposed positions. C. Bridgeman explained the roles and responsibilities of each position respectively and discussed asset management practices.

- **'Part Time Special Events and Sustainability Co-ordinator' (p. 82):** Committee Members sought clarification on the Town's sustainability portfolio. G. Romanowski explained the division of responsibilities for the Town's sustainability portfolio between policy and implementation roles.

- **'Seasonal – Waterfront (2)' (p. 84):** Committee Members asked questions regarding support for Paradise Park and the whole of the Ajax waterfront. C. Bridgeman explained the duties and responsibilities of the proposed positions.

- **'Part Time Lead Audio Video Technician' (p. 86):** Committee Members sought clarification about the position's role in supporting mobile stage equipment at Town and public events. R. Gruber explained the roles and responsibilities of the position.

Committee Members further discussed the Town's community safety portfolio and inquired about the adequacy of existing resources. R. Gruber reviewed the history of the Town's community safety strategy, changes to provincial legislation, and growth in the IMPACT Ajax and community safety portfolios.

Motion

Moved by: M. Crawford

That staff be directed to prepare a report for the February 24th Council meeting regarding staffing and other resources required to support the Town's Community Safety portfolio.

CARRIED

Section 4: New/Expanded Programs & Initiatives

Members asked questions and made comments regarding New/Expanded Programs & Initiatives within Section 4 of the Operating Budget:

- **'Expansion of Festivals & Events Program' (p. 91):** Committee Members asked questions regarding consideration of revenue generation from the new proposed festivals and events. R. Gruber discussed the deployment and evaluation of new Town events and consideration of future revenue generation.

- **'Winter Control – Hours of Work (ESA) / Expanded Season' (p. 90):** Committee Members sought clarification regarding the details of the proposed winter control program expanded season. C. Bridgeman and Dana Smith, Manager of Operations & Fleet Services, reviewed the proposed expansion to the Town's winter control program and discussed legislative changes, requirements under the Employment Standards Act, use of contractual services, and proposed new staff positions.

Referral Motion

Moved by: S. Collier

That the 'Winter Control – Hours of Work (ESA) / Expanded Season' expanded program be referred back to staff for more information and a report at the February 24th Council meeting.

CARRIED

Section 5: Ajax Public Library

There were no questions from Committee Members on Section 5 of the Operating Budget.

6. Closing Public Comments/Questions

Chair Tyler Morin invited any final comments and questions from members of the public.

Chris Baker, 69 Darley Street, inquired about the calculation of increases to salaries and benefits, impacts of collective agreements, municipal grants and subsidies, the Community Improvement Plan (CIP) grant, increase to Ajax Public Library expenditures, and use of prior year's surplus. S. Baker noted upcoming collective agreement negotiations. S. Serrao reviewed municipal grants and subsidies, the new library branch at ARC Phase 2, and Financial Sustainability Plan policies governing the allocation of surplus funds. G. Romanowski explained the Town's Community Improvement Plan areas and associated grant processes.

Motion to Recess

Moved by: S. Collier

That the General Government Committee Operating Budget meeting be recessed.

CARRIED

The Committee meeting recessed at 9:19 p.m.

The Committee meeting resumed at 9:30 p.m.

7. Budget Recommendation

Alexander Harras, Manager of Legislative Services / Deputy Clerk, reviewed the amendments and referrals adopted by the Committee and explained the revised motion to approve the proposed 2020 Operating Budget.

Committee Members and Chair Tyler Morin thanked staff for their hard work in preparing the 2020 Operating Budget.

Moved by: S. Collier

That Council approve the 2020 total General Levy of $71,214,200 inclusive of transfers from the Debt Reduction, Strategic Initiatives, and Election Reserves as follows:

2019 General Levy (Property Taxes)	$ 67,341,200
2019 Assessment Growth	946,300
2020 Net budget increase	2,926,700
Total General Levy (Property Taxes)	**$ 71,214,200**

Subject to the direction provided to staff to bring forward reports to the February 24th Council meeting regarding staffing and other resources required to support the Town's Community Safety portfolio, and to provide further information regarding the Winter Control New/Expanded Program/Initiative.

CARRIED

8. Adjournment (9:37 p.m.)

Moved by: S. Lee

That the February 3, 2020 General Government Committee Operating Budget Meeting be adjourned.

CARRIED

Chair

D-Clerk